Baby whale surprises scientists

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The 2027 baby season for North Atlantic right whales has officially begun. The **calving** season lasts from November through April, and it is a particularly important stretch of time because the species is classified as **critically endangered** by the IUCN Red List. Scientists are closely monitoring these **baleen** whales because their numbers are so low. Yet even with all of that watching, one whale managed to keep a secret until September. Experts spotted a known female and her previously unidentified calf from last **calving** season near Anticosti Island, Quebec, Canada, according to the New England Aquarium.

The 38-year-old female right whale is called Silt. In addition to being a mother, Silt is also a grandmother and great-grandmother, and the new calf is her sixth baby known to scientists. 'Silt managed to fly under the radar of survey teams throughout the spring and summer,' according to the aquarium. Although scientists do not know exactly when or where her calf was born, she was briefly seen in the southeastern United States **calving** grounds in February, so it is possible the calf was born there.

More North Atlantic right whales are always good news. They are one of the most endangered large whales, and they are vulnerable to ship collisions and fishing gear **entanglement**. Almost exactly a year ago, scientists were happy to report that the species is showing signs of slowly **rebounding**. The 2024 estimate of around 384 North Atlantic right whales represents a 2.1 percent increase from the 2023 estimate. 'The population increase is really good news, and so far, what we've seen in 2025 is also good news,' New England Aquarium senior scientist Heather Pettis told Popular Science in October 2025. But she added that 384 individual whales is still incredibly low, and that scientists are cautiously optimistic because injuries from human activities continue.

Word Treasure

critically endangered -- It means a kind of animal is in danger of disappearing forever.

calving -- Calving is the time when mother whales give birth to their babies.

baleen -- Baleen whales have special plates in their mouths for filtering tiny food from seawater.

entanglement -- Entanglement means getting tangled up and trapped in something like fishing gear.

rebounding -- Rebounding means slowly growing again after getting smaller.

Background you need

North Atlantic right whales are baleen whales, which filter tiny food from seawater instead of hunting with teeth.

They are critically endangered, so scientists watch them closely, especially during the calving season from November through April, when mothers give birth to new calves.

Each new calf matters because the whole population is very small, and the whales can be hurt by ship collisions and fishing gear.

Survey teams track known whales by sight, but a mother and calf can still go unseen for months if they stay away from the usual survey areas.

Break it down

LEAD: The calving season for North Atlantic right whales has begun, and scientists found a surprise calf they did not know about.

KEY EVENT: Experts spotted the whale Silt with her previously unidentified calf near Anticosti Island.

+- WHO: Silt, a 38-year-old female North Atlantic right whale, and her new calf.

+- WHEN: The calf was from last calving season and was spotted in September, after Silt was briefly seen in the southeastern United States calving grounds in February.

+- WHY IT MATTERS: Silt's calf is her sixth baby known to scientists, and every new calf helps a critically endangered species.

EVIDENCE: The 2024 estimate of around 384 whales was a 2.1 percent increase from 2023, and scientists say what they have seen in 2025 is also good news.

OPEN QUESTION: Scientists do not know exactly when or where Silt's calf was born, and they remain cautious because injuries from human activities continue.

Why it matters

Every new right whale calf helps a critically endangered species recover, and protecting whales from ships and fishing gear matters for the whole ocean.

Test what you remember

1. When does the North Atlantic right whale calving season last?

- (A) From September through December
- (B) From May through August
- (C) From June through September
- (D) From November through April

2. Where were Silt and her previously unidentified calf spotted?

- (A) Near the coast of Iceland
- (B) Near the coast of Florida
- (C) Near the coast of Alaska
- (D) Near Anticosti Island, Quebec, Canada

3. How many babies is Silt known to scientists to have had, including the new calf?

- (A) Four
- (B) Eight
- (C) Six
- (D) Five

4. What did scientists NOT know about Silt's new calf?

- (A) That Silt had been seen in February
- (B) That Silt was a mother
- (C) That the calf was a right whale
- (D) Exactly when and where it was born

5. What are North Atlantic right whales vulnerable to?

- (A) Sharks and cold water
- (B) Ship collisions and fishing gear entanglement
- (C) Deep-sea volcanoes and icebergs
- (D) Loud music and bright lights

6. What was the 2024 estimate for North Atlantic right whales, and how did it compare with 2023?

- (A) Around 384 whales, a 2.1 percent increase from the 2023 estimate
- (B) Around 1,000 whales, the same as the 2023 estimate
- (C) Around 384 whales, a 21 percent increase from the 2023 estimate
- (D) Around 200 whales, a 2.1 percent decrease from the 2023 estimate

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: C 4: D 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. New England Aquarium: The aquarium says Silt managed to fly under the radar of survey teams throughout the spring and summer.

2. Heather Pettis, a New England Aquarium senior scientist: She says the population increase is really good news and what has been seen in 2025 is also good news, but she adds that 384 whales is still incredibly low and scientists are cautiously optimistic because injuries from human activities continue.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):